

International Trade

Import/export foundations, supply chains, negotiation, and global opportunity identification

- Level: All levels
- Format: Self-paced micro-lessons + exercises
- Estimated time: 6-10 hours
- Last update: 2025-12-26

International trade is how goods and services move across borders. This module teaches practical trade basics: sourcing, logistics, documentation, negotiation, pricing, and risk control.

Rule: Trade success comes from margins + logistics reliability + risk control, not from hype.

1. Learning Outcomes

By the end of this module, the learner will be able to:

- Understand import/export processes and key documentation
- Evaluate suppliers and manage quality risk
- Design pricing and margin models for trade deals
- Plan logistics, payment terms, and negotiation strategies

Prerequisites

- Basic business math (cost, margin)
- Ability to research suppliers and markets

2. Curriculum Map (Suggested Path)

Unit	Focus	Key Deliverable
1	Trade fundamentals and terminology	Trade glossary sheet
2	Sourcing and supplier evaluation	Supplier scorecard
3	Logistics and documentation	Shipping checklist
4	Pricing, margins, and payments	Deal margin model
5	Risk control and scaling	Trade risk plan

3. Core Concepts

Trade flow and Incoterms (high level)

Incoterms define who pays for shipping, insurance, and risk at each stage. Understanding them prevents expensive mistakes.

Supplier risk

The biggest trade risks are quality, delays, and miscommunication. Use clear specs and verification steps.

- Supplier verification
- Sample testing
- Quality control checkpoints
- Clear contract and penalties

Logistics as strategy

Lead time affects cashflow. Choose shipping mode based on urgency, cost, and reliability.

- Sea: cheaper, slower

- Air: fast, expensive
- Courier: small shipments

Payments and protection

Use payment terms that protect you (e.g., partial upfront + balance after inspection).
Avoid overpaying without proof.

4. Practical Toolkit

Use these templates and checklists while you learn. Keep them in your investor journal.

Supplier Scorecard

Select suppliers with objective criteria.

- Company verification and references
- Product compliance/certifications
- Sample quality and consistency
- Communication speed and clarity
- Payment terms and flexibility
- Production capacity and lead times

Shipment Checklist

Prevent missing documents and delays.

- Commercial invoice
- Packing list
- Bill of lading / airway bill
- Certificate of origin (if required)
- Insurance documents
- Customs clearance requirements

Deal Margin Model

Know your real profit after hidden costs.

- Unit cost + minimum order quantity
- Shipping + insurance + customs duties
- Warehousing and last-mile delivery
- Marketing/sales cost
- Target margin and break-even price

5. Hands-on Exercises

Find a trade opportunity

Pick a product category and evaluate demand and competition.

- Choose a niche product
- Research 3 competitor prices

- Estimate landed cost and possible margin

Output: Opportunity brief

Build a supplier short-list

Evaluate 3 suppliers and rank them.

- Collect supplier profiles
- Score each supplier using the scorecard
- Choose top 1 and define negotiation plan

Output: Supplier shortlist + negotiation notes

Design a shipment plan

Plan documents, timeline, and costs.

- Choose shipping method
- Write required documents list
- Write a timeline from order to delivery

Output: Shipping checklist and timeline

6. Quick Assessment (Self-Check)

Answer in 5-10 minutes. If you miss more than 2 questions, review Units 1-3.

- 1. What problem do Incoterms solve?
- 2. Name three common trade documents.
- 3. Why are samples important before a large order?
- 4. What is 'landed cost'?
- 5. Name two risks that can destroy a trade deal.

7. Mini Glossary

Incoterms: Standard terms defining responsibilities in shipping.

Landed cost: Total cost to bring goods to your location.

MOQ: Minimum order quantity.

Bill of lading: Document proving shipment details and ownership.

Customs duties: Taxes charged by governments on imports.

8. Next Steps

Combine trade execution skills with Digital Marketing to sell products, and Entrepreneurship to build a scalable company.

- Build one supplier scorecard for a real niche.
- Create one margin model before negotiating price.
- Document a repeatable import process.